DOCUMENT // PKM-SYS-001 // REV 2.1

THE POLYMATH'S OPERATING SYSTEM

A Second Brain for Learning, Creating & Living

Prepared: January 2026 | For interdisciplinary learners

This system integrates:

- Evidence-based learning science
- Knowledge management (Obsidian + Git)
- Life planning and goal-setting
- Language acquisition
- AI-augmented workflows
- Articulation and communication practice

Designed for:

- Technical depth with intellectual breadth
- Cross-domain connection finding
- Long-term knowledge retention
- Clear communication at any level
- Intentional life direction

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Foundation: How Memory Works

Before diving into techniques, it's worth understanding why certain methods work. Memory formation involves three stages: encoding (getting information in), consolidation (stabilising it), and retrieval (getting it back out). Most students focus almost exclusively on encoding—reading, highlighting, re-reading—whilst neglecting retrieval, which research consistently shows is where durable learning actually happens.

The Note-Taking Hierarchy

Research reveals a clear hierarchy in note-taking effectiveness for memory retention:

Method	Retention	Characteristics
Paper + Pen	19% over typing	Rich spatial information, tactile feedback, fixed physical locations create memory anchors
Tablet + Stylus	15% over typing	Handwriting benefits preserved, less spatial permanence, can be enhanced with deliberate personalisation
Typing	Baseline	Verbatim transcription tendency, shallow processing, superior for speed and organisation

The difference between paper and tablet appears to stem from spatial memory. Physical notebooks provide fixed locations, irregular strokes, folded corners, and other distinctive features that create retrievable spatial cues. Digital interfaces, with their uniform scrolling and standardised layouts, lack these anchors.

Optimising Tablet-Based Notes

Since you're using a tablet with stylus, implement these practices to capture more of the paper benefits:

- **Create spatial distinctiveness**: Use different colours, varying text sizes, hand-drawn diagrams, and margin annotations rather than uniform digital text
- **Maintain consistent notebook structure**: Keep the same organisational layout so your brain can form spatial expectations
- **Add unique visual markers**: Circles, arrows, boxes, underlines—anything that breaks uniformity
- **Avoid infinite scroll**: Work within fixed "page" boundaries where possible
- **Personalise aggressively**: The more unique each page looks, the more retrievable it becomes

Physical Foundations

Cognitive performance doesn't exist in isolation. Two factors have overwhelming evidence for their impact on learning and retention.

Sleep and Memory Consolidation

Sleep isn't rest—it's when memory consolidation actively occurs. During sleep, your brain replays the day's learning, strengthens important connections, and prunes irrelevant ones.

Key findings:

- Memory consolidation occurs primarily during slow-wave and REM sleep

- Sleep deprivation impairs encoding of new information by up to 40%
- A short nap (20–90 mins) after learning can improve retention
- Consistent sleep schedules matter more than total hours

Practical implications:
- Don’t sacrifice sleep to study more—it’s counterproductive
- Review difficult material before bed (it gets consolidated overnight)
- Maintain consistent sleep/wake times, even at weekends
- If you must cram, a few hours of sleep beats an all-nighter

Exercise and Cognitive Function
Physical exercise increases BDNF (brain-derived neurotrophic factor), which supports learning and memory. The effects are both acute (immediately after exercise) and chronic (from regular practice).

Practical implications:
- Schedule exercise, even brief walks, as part of your learning system
- Consider light exercise before difficult study sessions
- Don’t view exercise and study as competing for time—they’re synergistic

Core Techniques

These four techniques form the backbone of effective learning. They're ordered by impact—if you implement nothing else, implement active recall.

Active Recall

Principle: Retrieving information from memory strengthens that memory far more than re-exposure to the information.

The mechanism: When you struggle to remember something, you're strengthening the neural pathways that lead to that information. Re-reading feels productive because the information seems familiar, but familiarity is not the same as retrievability.

Implementation Protocol

> **After every learning session:**
>
> 1. Close your notes completely
> 2. Open a blank page in your tablet
> 3. Write everything you can remember about what you just learnt
> 4. Don't worry about organisation—dump everything
> 5. Only after you've exhausted your recall, open your notes and compare
> 6. Note what you missed in a different colour
> 7. Focus your next review on the gaps

The Question Method

At the end of each lecture or reading session, write three questions you should be able to answer based on what you learnt. **Do not answer them immediately**. Wait 48 hours, then answer from memory before checking.

For robotics coursework, these might look like:

- "What are the three conditions for a Jacobian singularity and why does each occur?"
- "How does the Extended Kalman Filter handle non-linear state transitions?"
- "What trade-offs distinguish A* from RRT in path planning?"

Spaced Repetition

Principle: Information reviewed at gradually increasing intervals is retained far longer than information reviewed in massed practice.

The mechanism: Each successful retrieval at a longer interval strengthens the memory and extends the time before it begins to fade. The optimal time to review something is just before you would forget it.

Implementation Protocol

For technical/factual content (equations, algorithms, definitions, theorems):

Use Anki or a similar spaced repetition system. The key is writing good cards:

> **Good card principles:**
>
> - One atomic fact per card
> - Include context (when/why would I use this?)
> - Add visual diagrams for spatial concepts
> - Write the card yourself—the act of formulation is itself learning
> - Include "boundary" cards: "When does this NOT apply?"

Example cards for robotics:

Front	Back
What does the manipulability ellipsoid tell us?	The ease of moving the end-effector in different directions. Elongated = good mobility in that direction. Sphere = isotropic. Flat = near singularity.
When does EKF fail?	Highly non-linear systems, multi-modal distributions, large initial uncertainty. Consider UKF or particle filters instead.

Daily commitment: 10–15 minutes. Non-negotiable. The power is in consistency over months, not intensity over days.

Interleaving

Principle: Mixing related topics during study produces better discrimination and transfer than blocking (studying one topic exhaustively before moving to the next).

The mechanism: Interleaving forces your brain to continually reload different mental schemas and identify which approach applies to which problem. This feels harder—and is—but the difficulty is desirable.

Implementation Protocol

For robotics, instead of spending a full session on control theory, then a full session on perception, then planning:

> **Interleaved session structure (90 mins):**
>
> - 25 min: Control theory problems
> - 5 min: Break
> - 25 min: Perception/state estimation problems
> - 5 min: Break
> - 25 min: Planning algorithms
> - 5 min: Reflect on connections between the three

The final reflection is crucial—this is where cross-domain insight emerges. Ask: "How does the uncertainty I dealt with in perception affect my planning assumptions? How does my controller handle errors from the planner?"

Elaborative Interrogation

Principle: Asking "why" and "how" questions about material—and generating answers—produces deeper encoding than simply reading.

The mechanism: Generating explanations forces you to connect new information to existing knowledge structures, creating multiple retrieval pathways.

Implementation Protocol

When encountering a new concept, don't just note what it is. Ask and answer:

- Why does this work?
- How does this relate to [something I already know]?
- When would this fail?
- What's the opposite approach and why isn't it used?

For your polymath approach, add:

- What's the analogous concept in [other field you're studying]?
- Who would disagree with this and why?

Knowledge Management System

A systematic approach to capturing, processing, and connecting knowledge using Obsidian and CLI AI tools.

Philosophy: Why This Structure

Your workflow involves two modes of note-taking that serve different purposes:

Handwritten (tablet + stylus): For capture during active learning—lectures, reading, thinking. Optimised for engagement and initial encoding. Spatial, visual, personal.

Typed (Obsidian markdown): For processed knowledge—synthesis, connection, retrieval. Optimised for search, linking, and AI integration. Structured, queryable, permanent.

The conversion process between them isn't busywork—it's a forced retrieval and elaboration pass. You re-engage with material, make decisions about what matters, and rephrase for clarity. This is active processing.

Vault Structure

This structure supports a full second brain: learning, creating, planning, and language acquisition.

```
vault/
├── 0-inbox/                # Quick captures, unprocessed thoughts
├── 1-fleeting/             # Handwritten note conversions
├── 2-literature/           # Notes on sources with citations
│   ├── books/
│   ├── papers/
│   └── lectures/
├── 3-permanent/            # Your synthesised ideas (atomic notes)
│   ├── robotics/
│   ├── philosophy/
│   ├── economics/
│   └── cross-domain/
├── 4-essays/
│   ├── seeds/
│   ├── drafts/
│   └── published/
├── 5-prompts/              # AI prompt templates
├── 6-daily/                # Daily notes
├── 7-reviews/              # Weekly/monthly/quarterly reviews
├── 8-planning/             # Life planning and goals
│   ├── vision/             # Long-term vision documents
│   ├── yearly/             # Annual plans and reviews
│   ├── quarterly/          # 3-month sprints
│   ├── monthly/            # Monthly objectives
│   └── projects/           # Active project tracking
├── 9-languages/            # Language learning
│   ├── japanese/           # (or whatever languages you're learning)
│   │   ├── vocabulary/
│   │   ├── grammar/
│   │   ├── immersion-log/
│   │   └── resources/
│   └── [other-languages]/
├── 10-personal/            # Personal development
│   ├── values/             # Core values and principles
│   ├── habits/             # Habit tracking and systems
│   ├── health/             # Health and fitness notes
│   └── relationships/      # (optional)
├── templates/
└── assets/
```

Note Types and Templates

Fleeting Notes

Converted handwritten notes that may or may not develop further. Low friction, minimal structure.

```
---
type: fleeting
created: {{date}}
source: lecture/reading/thought
status: raw
---

# {{title}}

[Content from handwritten notes, lightly edited]

## Questions raised
-

## Potential connections
-
```

Literature Notes

Notes on external sources. Always include citation and your own synthesis—never just quotes.

```
---
type: literature
created: {{date}}
source: "{{author}}, {{title}}, {{year}}"
tags: []
---

# {{title}}

## Core argument
[One paragraph in your own words]

## Key concepts
- **Concept 1**: [Your understanding]
- **Concept 2**: [Your understanding]

## My response
[What do you think? How does this connect to what you know?]

## Links
- [[Related permanent note]]
- [[Another connection]]
```

Permanent Notes

Your own ideas, synthesised and atomic. One idea per note. These are the core of your knowledge system.

```
---
type: permanent
created: {{date}}
modified: {{date}}
tags: []
confidence: low/medium/high
---

# {{title}}

[A single, well-developed idea in your own words. Should be
understandable without context. Aim for 100-300 words.]

## Supporting evidence
- [[Literature note 1]]
- [[Literature note 2]]

## Connections
- [[Related permanent note]]: [Why they connect]
- [[Note from different domain]]: [The cross-domain insight]

## Open questions
-
```

```
## ELI5
[Can you explain this in one simple sentence?]
```

Essay Seeds

Ideas that might become essays. Low friction capture.

```
---
type: seed
created: {{date}}
status: raw/developing/ready
domain: robotics/philosophy/economics/cross-domain
---

# {{title}}

## Observation
[What did you notice?]

## Tension
[What's surprising, contradictory, or unexplained?]

## Potential thesis
[What might you argue?]

## Supporting notes
- [[Note 1]]
- [[Note 2]]

## What's needed to develop this?
-
```

Daily Workflow

When	Activity	Duration
Start of day	Git pull: `vault-sync`	30 sec
During day	Handwritten notes on tablet during lectures/reading	—
Evening	Anki review	10–15 min
Evening	Convert handwritten notes to markdown (synthesis, not transcription)	30–45 min
Evening	Add links, update connections in permanent notes	10–15 min
Evening	Capture any essay seeds	5 min
End of day	Git commit and push: `vault-save`	30 sec

Conversion Guidelines

When converting handwritten notes to markdown:

Do:

- Synthesise and compress—what's the essence?
- Rephrase in your own words
- Add structure and links
- Note what you don't understand
- Add the ELI5 version

Don't:

- Transcribe verbatim
- Convert everything—some fleeting notes should stay fleeting
- Worry about perfection—this is a living system

Triage framework:

- **Convert immediately**: Key insights, concepts you'll build on, cross-domain connections
- **Convert later**: Supporting details, examples, context
- **Leave handwritten**: Meeting notes, temporary calculations, things you understand fully

Git and GitHub Integration

Version control transforms your vault from a static knowledge store into a living history of your intellectual development.

Why Git for a Knowledge Vault?

Version history: See how your understanding evolved. Compare your explanation of a concept from 6 months ago to today.

Backup: Your vault is safe even if your device fails. GitHub provides offsite redundancy.

Cross-device sync: Work on your desktop, laptop, or any machine with Git access.

Atomic commits as learning markers: Each commit can represent a meaningful learning event—"finally understood X," "connected Y to Z."

Diff as reflection tool: `git diff` shows exactly what changed in your thinking.

Initial Setup

```
# Navigate to your vault
cd ~/obsidian-vault

# Initialise git repository
git init

# Create .gitignore
cat > .gitignore << 'EOF'
# Obsidian workspace (device-specific)
.obsidian/workspace.json
.obsidian/workspace-mobile.json
.obsidian/plugins/recent-files-obsidian/data.json
.trash/
.DS_Store
*.tmp
*~
EOF

# Initial commit
git add .
git commit -m "Initial vault setup"

# Create GitHub repository (via gh CLI or web interface)
gh repo create obsidian-vault --private --source=. --push
```

Commit Workflow

Trigger	Commit Message Convention
End of daily note conversion	daily: YYYY-MM-DD notes processed
New permanent note created	add: [note title] - [brief description]
Significant update to existing note	update: [note title] - [what changed]
New essay draft	draft: [essay title]
Essay published	publish: [essay title]
Weekly review complete	review: week of YYYY-MM-DD
New connection discovered	connect: [note A] ↔ [note B]

Daily Git Routine

Add this to your evening workflow:

```
# Add to ~/.bashrc or ~/.zshrc
alias vault-save='cd ~/obsidian-vault && git add . && \
  git commit -m "daily: $(date +%Y-%m-%d)" && git push'
```

```
alias vault-sync='cd ~/obsidian-vault && git pull'
alias vault-log='cd ~/obsidian-vault && git log --oneline -20'
```

Then just run `vault-save` at the end of each day.

Using Git History for Reflection

```
# See how a note evolved
git log --oneline -- "3-permanent/robotics/ekf.md"

# Find when you made a connection
git log --grep="connect:" --oneline

# Review a week's learning
git log --after="2025-01-08" --before="2025-01-15" --oneline

# Quarterly reflection—count all additions
git log --after="2024-10-01" --before="2025-01-01" \
  --grep="add:" --oneline | wc -l
```

CLI AI Integration

With your notes as markdown files, CLI tools like Claude Code can engage with your knowledge base directly.

High-Value AI Operations

Generate Anki cards from notes:

```
claude "Read [[Note title]] and generate 5 Anki cards testing
       the key concepts. Format as markdown table with Front/Back."
```

Find connections:

```
claude "I just wrote [[New note]]. Based on my existing notes
       in 3-permanent/, what connections should I make?"
```

Socratic questioning on a topic:

```
claude "Read my notes on [topic] and quiz me. Ask increasingly
       difficult questions until I can't answer."
```

Gap identification:

```
claude "Analyse my notes in 3-permanent/robotics/. What
       prerequisite concepts am I missing?"
```

The Articulation Framework

Knowing something and being able to communicate it are different skills. This section develops your ability to explain clearly at any level of complexity.

The Ladder of Abstraction

Every concept can be explained at multiple levels. Mastery means being able to move fluidly up and down this ladder.

Level	Characteristics	Example: PID Control
Expert	Technical precision, assumes domain knowledge	A closed-loop control algorithm using proportional, integral, and derivative terms to minimise error
Professional	Accurate but accessible to adjacent fields	A feedback system that continuously adjusts output based on current error, accumulated past error, and rate of change
Layperson	Conceptual accuracy without jargon	A system that watches the difference between where you are and where you want to be, then makes corrections
ELI5	Core intuition through analogy	Like a thermostat that also learns how fast the room heats up and remembers if it's been cold for a while

Why ELI5 Matters

The ability to explain simply is not "dumbing down"—it's demonstrating genuine understanding. When you can only explain something technically, you may be pattern-matching on jargon without grasping the underlying concept.

Benefits of ELI5 practice:

- Reveals gaps in your own understanding
- Forces identification of core intuitions vs. technical details
- Develops analogy-finding as a skill
- Makes your knowledge useful to more people
- Prepares you for teaching, leadership, and communication roles

The target: Be able to ELI5 80% of your knowledge—everything except highly technical details that genuinely require specialist background.

Analogy Development

Good analogies share **structural** features with the target concept, not just surface features.

Weak (surface)	Strong (structural)
"A neural network is like a brain"	"A neural network is like a voting committee where each member specialises in noticing different patterns"
"Recursion is like a mirror reflecting a mirror"	"Recursion is like looking up a word in the dictionary and finding it defined

	using another word you also need to look up”

Analogy Practice Protocol

```
1. Identify the structural features (relationships, processes, constraints)
2. Ask: “What everyday situation has similar structure?”
3. Draft an analogy
4. Test: Does the analogy break down in misleading ways?
5. Refine or try another domain
6. Record the best analogy in your permanent note
```

The Feynman Technique (Enhanced)

Basic Protocol

1. **Choose a concept** you want to understand deeply
2. **Explain it in writing** as if to someone with no background
3. **Identify gaps**—where did you get stuck, hand-wave, or use jargon?
4. **Return to sources** and fill the gaps
5. **Simplify and use analogies**
6. **Repeat** until your explanation is smooth

Enhanced Protocol

Add these steps:

Level practice: Write the explanation at three levels—expert, educated layperson, ELI5. Can you do all three?

AI feedback: Use an AI to critique your explanation:

```
“I’ve explained [concept] below. Identify:
1. Gaps in my explanation
2. Places where I used jargon without explaining
3. Logical jumps I didn’t justify
4. What a confused student would still not understand
5. How to make my analogy more precise“
```

Verbal Fluency

Written articulation and spoken articulation are different skills. Spoken explanation requires real-time retrieval, no editing, reading your audience, and managing pace.

Practice Methods

Explain aloud to yourself: When reviewing notes, speak your explanations instead of just thinking them. Uncomfortable but effective.

Record yourself: Explain a concept in 2 minutes, record it, listen back. You’ll notice verbal tics, unclear passages, and pacing issues.

The “explain to a friend” test: Regularly explain what you’re learning to non-specialist friends or family. Their questions reveal what’s not as clear as you thought.

Weekly Verbal Practice (15-20 mins)

Pick one concept from your notes each week. Practise explaining it:

- In 2 minutes (lift pitch)
- In 30 seconds (headline version)
- At three different levels (expert, layperson, child)

Life Planning System

Your vault isn't just for knowledge—it's for directing that knowledge toward a meaningful life.

The Planning Hierarchy

Goals cascade from vision down to daily action:

Horizon	Purpose	Review
10-year vision	Direction and identity—who do you want to become?	Yearly
5-year goals	Major life milestones and transitions	Yearly
1-year plan	Concrete objectives with measurable outcomes	Quarterly
Quarterly sprint	Focused execution on 2-3 priorities	Monthly
Monthly objectives	Specific deliverables and habits	Weekly
Weekly plan	Task allocation and time blocking	Daily

Templates

10-Year Vision

```
---
type: planning/vision
horizon: 10-year
created: {{date}}
last_reviewed: {{date}}
---

# 10-Year Vision ({{year + 10}})

## Who I Want to Become
[Not what you want to have—who you want to BE. What kind of
person? What values embodied?]

## Life Domains

### Career / Professional
[Where are you professionally? What have you built or contributed?]

### Knowledge / Intellectual
[What do you understand deeply? What are you known for?]

### Relationships / Community
[Who is in your life? What role do you play for others?]

### Health / Physical
[What is your relationship with your body and health?]

### Financial
[What does financial security/freedom look like?]

## The Non-Negotiables
[What MUST be true for this to feel like a life well-lived?]
```

```
## What I'm Willing to Sacrifice
[What trade-offs are you consciously accepting?]
```

Quarterly Sprint

```
---
type: planning/quarterly
quarter: Q1
year: {{year}}
status: active
---

# {{year}} Q1 Sprint (Jan – Mar)

## Quarter Theme
[One sentence—what's the primary thrust?]

## Priorities (Max 3)

### Priority 1: [Name]
- *Definition of done*:
- *Why this quarter*:
- *Weekly milestones*:
  - Week 1-2:
  - Week 3-4:
  - Week 5-6:
  - Week 7-8:
  - Week 9-10:
  - Week 11-12:

## What I'm NOT Doing This Quarter
[Explicit de-prioritisation—what are you saying no to?]

## Quarter Review (Complete at end)
- Status: Complete / Partial / Missed
- Reflection:
- Carry forward:
```

Review Rituals

Weekly Planning (30 min, Sunday or Monday)

```
1. Review quarterly priorities—are you on track?
2. Review last week: What got done? What didn't?
3. Identify this week's 3 most important outcomes
4. Time-block the week for deep work on priorities
5. Identify potential obstacles and plan around them
```

Monthly Review (1 hour)

```
1. Progress on quarterly priorities (percentage, blockers)
2. Habit consistency check
3. What did I learn this month?
4. What connections between my learning and my goals emerged?
5. Adjustments needed for next month
```

Quarterly Review (Half day)

```
1. Complete quarterly sprint review
2. Assess progress on annual objectives
3. Review 5-year goals—still relevant?
4. Plan next quarter's priorities
5. Identify skill gaps to address
6. Celebrate wins (seriously—acknowledge progress)
```

Annual Review (Full day, late December)

```
1. Complete annual plan review
2. Life domains audit: How’s each area?
3. Review 10-year vision—update if needed
4. Update 5-year goals based on progress and changed desires
5. Create next year’s annual plan
6. Review git history: How has your thinking evolved?
7. Gratitude practice: What are you thankful for this year?
```

Language Learning Integration

Language acquisition fits naturally into this system—it benefits from spaced repetition, active recall, and regular practice.

Folder Structure for Languages

```
9-languages/
├── japanese/
│   ├── vocabulary/
│   │   ├── core-2000.md
│   │   ├── robotics-terms.md
│   │   └── expressions.md
│   ├── grammar/
│   ├── immersion-log/
│   │   └── 2025-01.md
│   ├── writing/
│   └── progress.md
└── [other-languages]/
```

Templates

Vocabulary Note

```
---
type: language/vocabulary
language: japanese
created: {{date}}
---

# [Word/Phrase]

## Reading
[Furigana or pronunciation]

## Meaning
[Definition in English]

## Context
[Example sentence in target language]
[Translation]

## Notes
[Nuance, formality level, common mistakes]

## Source
[Where did you encounter this?]
```

Monthly Immersion Log

```
---
type: language/immersion-log
language: japanese
month: 2025-01
---

# January 2025 Immersion Log

## Goals This Month
- [ ] X hours of listening
- [ ] X hours of reading
- [ ] X writing sessions
- [ ] X speaking sessions

## Listening Log
| Date | Content | Duration | Notes |
|------|---------|----------|-------|
| 01-15 | [Podcast] | 30min | Understood ~70% |

## Monthly Reflection
- Total immersion hours:
- What improved:
- Still struggling with:
- Focus for next month:
```

Integration with Existing Systems

Daily Integration

When	Activity	Duration
Morning	Anki review (include language deck)	15-20 min
Commute/Gym	Listening immersion (podcasts, audiobooks)	Variable
Evening	Reading practice OR writing practice	15-30 min
Weekly	Speaking practice (tutor, language exchange)	60 min

Cross-Domain Connection
Your polymath approach applies here too:

- **Robotics papers in target language**: Combine domain learning with language practice
- **Philosophy texts in original language**: Many key works exist in German, French, Greek
- **Economic news in target language**: Different perspectives, vocabulary building

The Language Learning Mindset

Consistency over intensity: 30 minutes daily beats 4 hours on Saturday.

Embrace the plateau: Progress isn't linear. You'll feel stuck for weeks, then suddenly improve.

Output early: Don't wait until you're "ready" to speak or write. You're never ready. Start broken and improve.

Connect to identity: You're not "studying Japanese." You're "becoming someone who speaks Japanese."

Personal Growth and Reflection

A system for learning isn't just about knowledge accumulation—it's about becoming someone who thinks better.

Reflection Protocols

Daily Reflection (5 minutes)
At the end of each study day:
- What did I learn today that I didn't know yesterday?
- What confused me? (This is valuable information, not failure)
- What connection did I notice?

Weekly Reflection (15 minutes)

Understanding:
- What concept am I most confident about now?
- What am I still confused about?
- What question am I carrying into next week?

Process:
- What study method worked well?
- What felt ineffective?
- What adjustment will I try?

Connection:
- What unexpected link did I notice across domains?
- What would I like to explore further?

Monthly Reflection (30 minutes)

Knowledge audit:
- What topics have I covered this month?
- Where are the gaps?
- What should I prioritise next month?

Articulation check:
- Pick 3 concepts from this month. Can I ELI5 them?
- Where do I struggle to explain clearly?

Growth evidence:
- What can I do now that I couldn't do 30 days ago?
- What would past-me find impressive about current-me?

Tracking Progress

Quantitative Tracking
- **Anki stats**: Cards mature, retention rate over time
- **Essays**: Count of drafts, count of published pieces
- **Notes**: Growth of permanent notes over time
- **Connections**: New cross-domain links added

Qualitative Tracking
Keep a "wins" document where you note:
- Concepts that finally clicked
- Explanations that landed well
- Times your cross-domain knowledge provided unique insight
- Feedback from others on your thinking or communication

Review this when motivation flags.

AI-Augmented Learning

AI tools can significantly accelerate learning when used deliberately. The key is using AI to increase retrieval and elaboration, not to bypass them.

High-Value Applications

Socratic Questioning

> "I've just studied [topic]. Ask me increasingly difficult questions about it, starting with fundamentals and progressing to edge cases and applications. Don't give me the answers—just ask. After each response, tell me if I'm correct, what I'm missing, and then ask a harder question."

Connection Finding

> "I've learnt about [specific concept] in robotics. I'm also interested in philosophy and economics. What analogous concepts, frameworks, or problems exist in these fields? Focus on deep structural similarities rather than surface metaphors."

Explanation Feedback

> "I'm going to explain [concept] as if you know nothing. After my explanation, tell me:
> 1. What I explained well
> 2. What was unclear or ambiguous
> 3. What I assumed without stating
> 4. What logical gaps exist
> 5. What a student would still be confused about"

Pre-Reading Scaffolding

> "I'm about to read [paper title] on [topic]. Give me:
> 1. The 5 key concepts I'll encounter and one-sentence definitions
> 2. The relationships between these concepts
> 3. What prerequisite knowledge I need
> 4. What questions this material is trying to answer
>
> Be concise—this is orientation, not a substitute for reading."

Anti-Patterns

> **Avoid these uses**—they bypass the cognitive processes that produce learning:
>
> - Asking for summaries instead of creating your own
> - Getting answers to problem sets without attempting them first
> - Using AI-generated explanations as your primary source
> - Copying AI output into notes without processing it
> - Using AI to avoid the struggle of articulation

The principle: AI should increase the difficulty of your cognitive engagement, not reduce it.

The Weekly System

This schedule integrates everything into a sustainable rhythm.

Daily Practices

When	Activity	Duration
Start of day	Git pull: `vault-sync`	30 sec
Morning	Anki review	10–15 min
During day	Handwritten notes during lectures/reading	—
After each lecture	Write 3 retrieval questions (don't answer yet)	5 min
Evening	Convert handwritten notes to markdown	30–45 min
Evening	Add links, connections; capture essay seeds	15 min
Evening	Daily reflection	5 min
End of day	Git commit and push: `vault-save`	30 sec

48-Hour Delayed Retrieval

Questions written on Day 1 → Answered (from memory) on Day 3

Keep a simple log:
- Date of questions
- Date due for retrieval
- Score (how many could you answer fully?)
- Gaps identified

Weekly Review Session (90–120 min)

Time	Activity
0–15 min	Blank page recall: What were the key concepts from this week?
15–30 min	Compare with notes, identify gaps
30–50 min	Interleaved problem practice across topics
50–70 min	AI Socratic session on weakest area
70–90 min	Weekly reflection; update seed bank
90–105 min	Verbal practice: Pick one concept, explain at 3 levels
105–120 min	CLI AI review of week's notes

Essay Cycle

Cadence	Activity
Weekly (2 hrs)	Draft one essay synthesising something from the week or seed bank

Monthly	Review essay drafts, select one to polish for publication
Quarterly	Review published essays—what themes are emerging?

The Essay Practice

Writing essays serves multiple learning functions: retrieval practice, elaboration, generation effect, and forced articulation.

Principles

Scope
Constrain ruthlessly. A tight argument about one idea beats a survey of many.

Weak scope	Strong scope
An overview of robot path planning	Why sampling-based planners dominate high-dimensional configuration spaces
Ethics in autonomous systems	The alignment problem in autonomous vehicles is structurally identical to AI safety
Sensor fusion techniques	When does the Kalman filter assumption of Gaussian noise actually hold?

Audience
Write for your past self—specifically, what would have helped you understand this faster a week ago?

Differentiation
Include at least one non-obvious connection. Given your breadth across philosophy, economics, and robotics, this is your differentiator.

Quality Threshold for Publication

Publish if the essay:

- Makes a non-obvious claim that you can defend
- Contains at least one insight you haven't seen written elsewhere
- Would be useful to someone in your field or adjacent to it
- Demonstrates thinking rather than summarising

Keep private if:

- It's primarily summary for your own understanding
- The insight is too context-dependent to be useful to others
- You can't articulate why someone should read it

The SCQA Framework

Situation → Complication → Question → Answer

- **Situation**: What's the context your reader needs?
- **Complication**: What tension, problem, or change creates the need for your essay?
- **Question**: What specific question does this raise?
- **Answer**: Your thesis—the rest of the essay supports this

The Seed Bank

Maintain a running note of half-formed ideas, interesting tensions, or questions you can't yet answer.

Review monthly. Some seeds will die. Others will merge. A few will be ready to grow.

Quick Reference

Daily Checklist

- ☐ `vault-sync` (git pull)
- ☐ Anki review (10–15 min)
- ☐ Post-lecture: Write 3 retrieval questions
- ☐ Evening: Convert handwritten notes to markdown
- ☐ Evening: Add connections, capture seeds
- ☐ Evening: 5-min reflection
- ☐ `vault-save` (git commit + push)

The Four Core Techniques

1. **Active Recall**: Retrieve, don't re-read
2. **Spaced Repetition**: Distributed practice over time
3. **Interleaving**: Mix related topics, don't block
4. **Elaboration**: Ask why, connect to existing knowledge

The Ladder of Abstraction

Expert → Professional → Layperson → ELI5

If you can't ELI5 it, you don't fully understand it.

Git Commit Prefixes

`add:` new note · `update:` revision · `connect:` link notes

`draft:` essay WIP · `publish:` essay done · `daily:` routine

The AI Principle

AI should increase cognitive difficulty, not reduce it.

Essay Quality Test

Before publishing, can you answer: **"Why should someone read this?"**

If the answer is just "to learn about X"—don't publish.

If it's "because I show that X implies Y, which isn't obvious"—publish.

THE POLYMATH'S OPERATING SYSTEM

The best system is the one you'll actually use.